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Ethnocentrism Vs Cultural Relativism

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Ethnocentrism

- The fundamental principle underlying the **in-group feeling** is ethnocentrism.
- W.G. Sumner defines ethnocentrism as **"that view of things in which one's own group is the centre of everything and others are scaled and rated with reference to it".**
- It is an assumption that the values, the ways of life and the attitudes of one's own group are superior to those of others.
- The culture of the out-group is looked upon with hatred and even contempt.

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Nature of Ethnocentrism

1. **Ethnocentrism involves double moral standards**
   - "...there are two codes of morals and two sets of mores, one for the comrade inside and other for the stranger outside..."
2. **Ethnocentrism is a universal phenomenon**
   - Every group, past or present, small or large is ethnocentric
3. **Ethnocentrism involves attitudes of superiority**
   - Every group thinks of itself as possessing highest values and having accomplished the most.

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Roots of Ethnocentrism

- Roots of Ethnocentrism lie in the primordial sentiment of an individual's identification of the group
- **Gumplowicz** calls this **SYNGENISM**

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Primitive Vs Modern Societies

- Ethnocentrism of primitive people differs from that of modern people
- Ethnocentrism is less wide and assumes **more peaceful form of expression** among civilized people.
- **"ethnocentrism in modern nations is really the sentiment of patriotism in all its philosophical fullness... in its rationality and its extravagance and exaggeration".**

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Levels of Ethnocentrism

1. **Positive Ethnocentrism**:
   - One's own life to be preferred over all the others
   - The most popular level
   - It is this form that gives people their sense of people-hood, group identity and a place in history

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Levels of Ethnocentrism

2. Negative Ethnocentrism:

- When one's own group becomes the centre of everything
- All others are scaled and rated with reference to it

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Levels of Ethnocentrism

3. **Extreme Negative Ethnocentrism**:
   - When a powerful group imposes its rule on another group and
   - Actively depreciates things the other group holds as valuable

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Ethnocentrism & Anthropology

- All human societies are ethnocentric to some extent
- Anthropologists strive to be as non-ethnocentric as possible
- Franz Boas' Cultural Relativism and Malinowski's Functionalism are guides to produce objective studies

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Cultural Relativism

- It is a method whereby social and cultural phenomena are perceived and described

  1. With **scientific analysis and detachment.**
  2. In terms of their **significance in a given socio-cultural context.**
  3. **Without using the values of one culture to judge the worth of another.**

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Why Cultural Relativism?

- Beliefs are relative to the society and are NOT always COMPARABLE between societies
- The meaning and function of a trait is relative to its own cultural setting
- **A trait is neither good or bad in itself** and it is good or bad only with reference to the culture in which it functions
- **There are only few universally true absolutes that men should do, think or act -** everything else is historically and socially bound to a particular situation

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Cultural Relativism as a method in Anthropology

- Franz Boas calls Cultural Relativism as Axiomatic (necessary and self-evident)
- Herskovitz "Judgments are based on experience and experience is interpreted by each individual in terms of his own enculturation"
- However, C/R DOES NOT give intellectual warrant for some group to behave in whatever way they deem fit - its appropriateness should always be evaluated based on wider cultural significance.

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EC VS CR

Ethnocentrism	Cultural Relativism
Exclusive	Inclusive
Closed Mind	Open Mind
Culturally Insensitive	Culturally Sensitive

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